STATE SCAN

WEST BENGAL: THE NEW SCOURGE PG 16 | DELHI: 2047, A CAPITAL MAKEOVER PG 18



IANS

CRUMBLING GROUND Debris blocks a road after a landslide near the Congress state HQ, Shimla, Jul. 28; (right) CM Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu

▶ HIMACHAL PRADESH

SHIMLA HIT BY FISCAL LANDSLIDE

Capital outlays slashed. Revenue gobbled up by salaries, pensions. Sukhu raises alarm at New Delhi turning off a vital tap—but sceptics abound

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

JUST BEFORE SEPTEMBER ARRIVED, WITH MONSOON-RAVAGED infrastructure all around, Himachal Pradesh chief minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu was heard making an unusual statement. His government had written to the Centre that it wished to cut the sanctioned strength of the state's Indian Administrative Service (IAS) cadre from 153 posts to 130. In fact, he may have gone down to 110, if not for resistance from within the service. The latter quibbled that Sukhu was resorting to empty rhetoric with wrong math, since he was slashing posts that were vacant anyway! But why was the CM striking a pose with his fingers on the scissors?

States usually move in the other direction: they want more bureaucrats, and there aren't enough. India's pool of IAS officers is presently 5,577, against 6,877 sanctioned posts, a shortage of 19 per cent or so. The IPS is short by 505 officers. The Indian Forest Service is worst placed, with 2,151 officers against 3,193 sanctioned. In 2026,